A beginner's guide to the night sky

You do not need a telescope to start. Find a spot away from streetlights, let your eyes adjust for twenty minutes, and look up on a clear, moonless night.

Start with a few landmarks: the Big Dipper points to the North Star, and Orion's three-star belt is easy to spot in winter. Bright steady lights that do not twinkle are usually planets, such as Venus and Jupiter.

A free star-chart app on your phone will name what you see. When you want more, a pair of ordinary binoculars shows the moons of Jupiter and many star clusters.